

GUEST COLUMN

CASTE AGAINST CITIZENS

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Our democracy is determined to show the world that whatever others can do, we can do worse. If in this process, individual initiatives are killed, standards lowered, and professional ethics compromised, there is no cause for worry. We can still sink a lot lower.

We want to be a world power, but our politicians will not let that happen. Sadly, a number of intellectuals are on their side digging holes for all of us to jump into. Instead of thinking citizenship, our democratically elected leaders are thinking caste and family. Instead of admonishing them, many of our intellectuals see merit in all of this as they supposedly reflect popular opinion.

Among other things, the 'people's' opinion fetish works best when it is geared towards yesterday. We were people once upon a time in the distant past, but today we are citizens. This aspect is not reflected in our politics. The bulk of our elected leaders, the three Yadavs included, would happily slide down deep black holes to represent the people. Ask them to look ahead and deliver to citizens and they would lose their way.

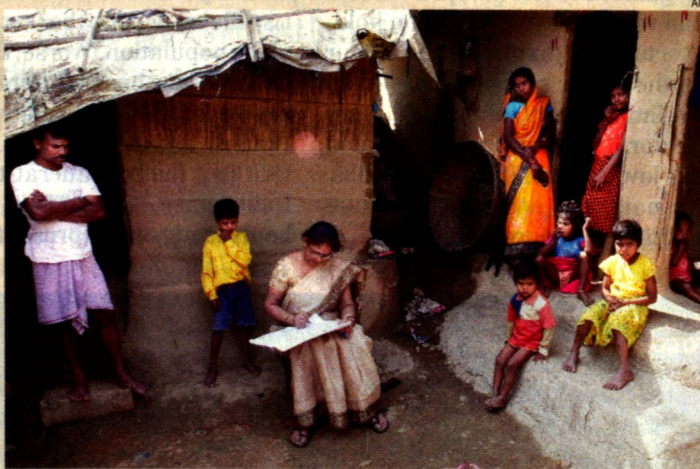
As citizens we do not need caste but we need development, growth, employment and clean air. We need to think as one so that the basis of our existence is rooted in common factors and not in divisive ones. But when we think as people, none of this is our concern. Instead we are overwhelmed by the need to dominate other people. So in a democracy of people, there is always caste against caste, language against language, religion against religion. As citizenship is blind to these considerations, our politicians consider it a handicap.

Censuses have always reflected the needs of citizens so that policy can be adequately framed to aid the public. The census is a document in service of the future and not to serve past prejudices or sectional interests. If the census today is pressured to include caste numbers then the game is clear. Caste will henceforth be the basis of social policy and not citizenship. The idea of the public is junked and

the notion of caste, kin, clan and religion will rule the day.

When several intellectuals supported OBC reservations and, indeed, reservations of all kinds in perpetuity, they should have known which side they were cheering for. The politics of caste can perhaps be justified as people's voices amplified, but it certainly muffles the call of citizenship.

Once caste numbers are published there will be endless quarrels over whether or not the facts were correctly gathered, the numbers properly added and so on. Brotherhoods will soon emerge, canvassing memberships to certain castes with tempting offers of quick jobs, early promotions and happy marriages. To make all of this



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NATIONAL CENSUS
WORKER RUMIMA DAS
(CENTRE) COLLECTS
INFORMATION AT A
VILLAGE IN GUWAHATI

work, the traditional system will have to be properly tanked up with bad blood with enough in reserve to spill out on to the streets.

As is plainly visible already, caste politicians are not done yet with reservations. They are now claiming new territory by asking for control over marriage, not just through informal control, which was always the case, but through the law. If they have their way again, marriage through choice will become another victim of yesterday, and once again, citizens will be trampled in the name of the people.

The most successful democracies have been forward-looking. They open a window where nobody thought one existed. They create goals that are not framed by tradition, but by projects that look ahead and create bonds between citizens. Once democracy forgets its citizenship mission, then in real terms there is little to distinguish it